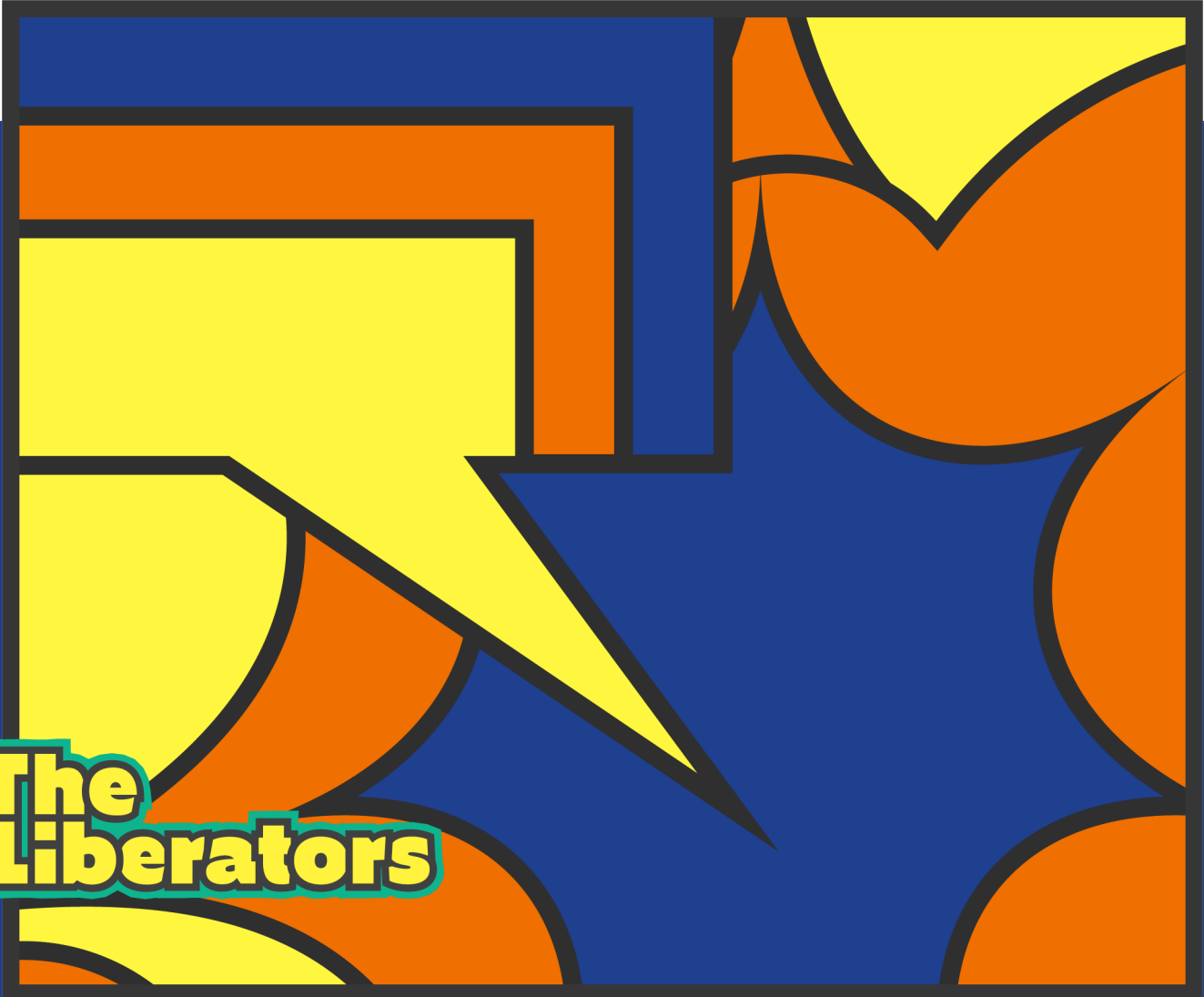


Use Improv Prototyping To Playfully Explore Five Styles Of Responding To Conflict

A do-it-yourself workshop to inspect five styles of responding to conflict, address the one's team members recognize, and make improvements accordingly.



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

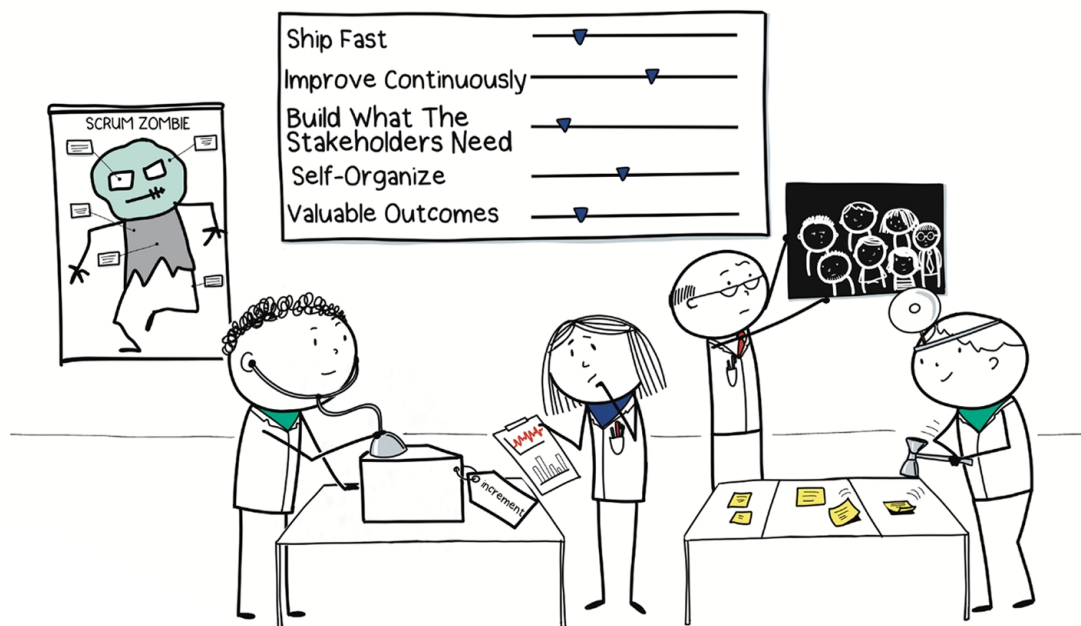
Conflicts in groups are often "invisible elephants". Instead of what we expect conflicts to be — raised voices and slamming doors — conflicts are often subtle and take place below the waterline. Like a team where everyone feels they are contributing more than the others. Or one person who feels they can't get their voice in because another person is claiming all the air time in conversations. Research shows how even light conflict can cause team productivity to drop, as members are increasingly occupied with the fall-out.

We created this do-it-yourself workshop to familiarize your team with the Dual Concern Model for conflict (Pruitt & Rubin, 1986). It offers five common styles of how people respond to conflict. We use the Liberating Structure "Improv Prototyping" to encourage your team to playfully explore the different styles, address the ones they recognize, and make improvements accordingly.

Give it a try, and share the results. Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: With "5x5 Writing"

  15 min

Step 3: Introduce the Dual Concern Model For Conflict

 10 min

Step 4: Invite Participants To Share Thoughts And Ideas With Impromptu Networking

  15 min

Step 5: Act Out The Different Styles Of Responding To Conflict With "Improv Prototyping"

  45 min

Step 6: Personal Next Steps

  10 min

Step 7: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 100 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Improv Prototyping takes a bit of courage to facilitate, but its playful character is bound to offer a great experience!

Impact On Survival



Conflict decreases team productivity and safety, so this is definitely something you want to address.



How Conflicts Are About (Unmet) Needs

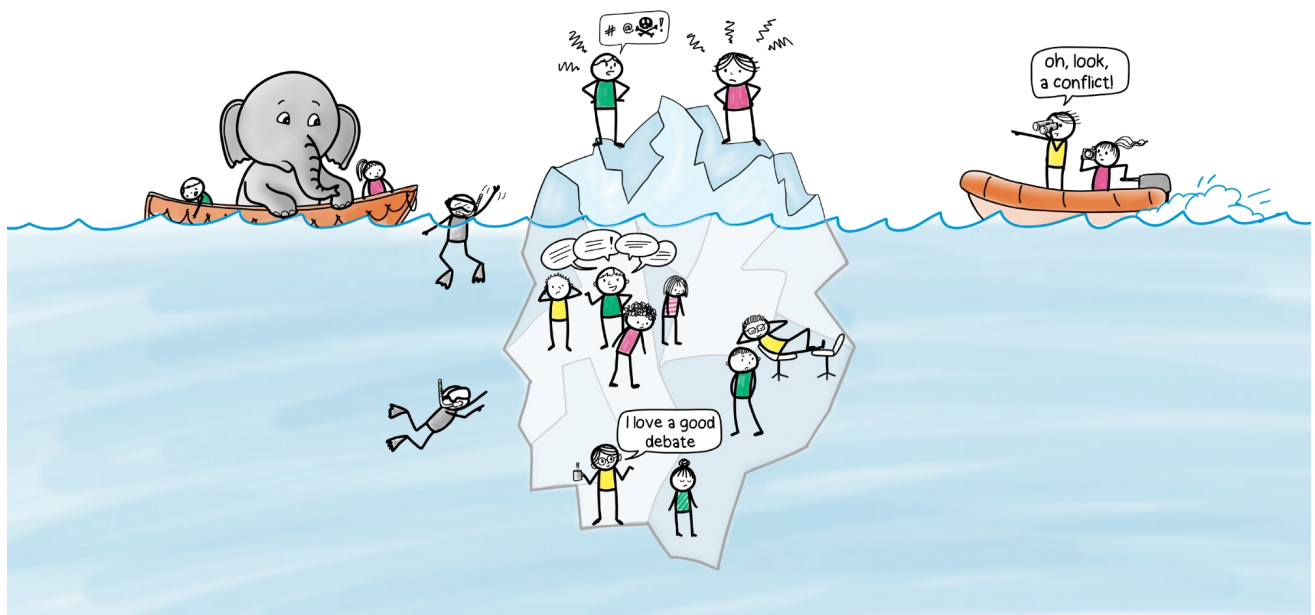
When is something a conflict? One distinction commonly made is between conflicts that are disagreements on how to proceed on a shared task and conflicts about feelings of animosity with another person. But this distinction is not clear-cut, as even a difference of opinion can be taken very personally (e.g. Simons and Peterson, 2000).

A simpler way to understand conflict is to understand it in terms of unmet needs. Some needs can be very tangible, such as a salary raise or getting something that is owned by someone else. Or it may be about getting someone to see your point of view. But most conflicts in our day-to-day life are about unmet social needs; the need to be seen and respected by others, accepted, heard and listened to, and feel valuable. The extent to which they manifest are deeply personal and influenced by our culture, personality, and history. These conflicts are often hard to see and often experienced acutely by one party but not at all by the other party.

Although light conflict is not necessarily a cause for alarm, scientific research overwhelmingly shows that all-but-the-lightest conflict harms the productivity of teams (De Dreu & Weingart, 2003). This means that effectively navigating conflicts is crucial for any group of people wanting to work together productively.

References

- Simons, T. & Peterson, R. (2000). Task conflict and relationship conflict in top management teams: The pivotal role of intragroup trust. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 85, 102–111
- De Dreu, C.K.W. & L.R. Weingart. 2003. Task versus relationship conflict, team performance, and team member satisfaction: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 88(4) 741–749



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team that wants to improve how they respond to conflict. It is possible to use it with multiple teams, stakeholders, or other people from the organization. You do need to pay attention to create an environment where everyone feels safe to practice and speak up.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- A (virtual) poster with the [Dual Concern Model for Conflict](#)

Resources

- Podcast episode by Christiaan Verwijs which was used as inspiration for this DIY workshop: [Conflict Styles, What Science Says & How Liberating Structures Can Help](#)
- Blog post: [Address The Elephant](#)
- Blog post: [Navigating Conflict, A Lifetime Of Work](#)



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: With "5x5 Writing"

Before we dive into the core topic of this workshop (The Dual Concern Model For Conflict), we first give the participants an opportunity to get their thinking started about what tension and conflict mean to them.

The Liberating Structure [10x10 Writing](#) (tweaked into 5x5 writing) is a great way to loosen people up and get their thinking started. It also creates a first opportunity to connect with others.

Invitation

1. I know there is a conflict in my team when ...
2. The most recent conflict I experienced in this team was ...
3. When I experience conflict in this team, I tend to ...
4. A not-so-helpful thing I sometimes do in conflicts is to ...
5. In conflict situations in this team, I wish I could ...

Steps

1. **1 min** Whether you're doing this virtually or in-person, ask everyone to sit down and take an empty piece of paper or an empty page in a notebook.
2. **2 min** Explain that you'll offer 5 sentences, one by one and that participants have a minute per sentence to write down the sentence and complete it with as many examples as they can think of. Emphasize that this is done in silence and in private.
3. **5 min** One by one, offer a sentence and wait one minute to give people time to write down as many examples as they can think of.
4. **2 min** Ask everyone to take a look at what they wrote down. Ask: "Looking back over your answers, mark patterns that immediately jump out at you".
5. **5 min** Invite people into pairs to share their notes and ideas. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.

Our Findings

- 10x10 Writing requires you to read the room. If everyone has already put their pen down, you can move to the next sentence. But also recognize that for you – as a facilitator – the timebox feels longer than for participants.



Step 3: Introduce the Dual Concern Model For Conflict

You start this workshop with a short introduction to the "Dual Concern Model For Conflict". The purpose of this step is to familiarize the participants with five different styles of responding to conflict. The explanation should be long enough to give everyone enough clarity to discuss it in the next step with Impromptu Networking, and short enough to stick within the timebox of 10 minutes.

Steps

- **5 min** Introduce the "Dual Concern Model For Conflict" and the five different styles of responding to conflict. Draw inspiration from the text we've included below.
- **2 min** Set the expectation that the participants will discuss the model in more detail in the next step, and it includes a joint debrief as well.
- **3 min** Answer questions that need clarification before the group moves into the next step, Impromptu Networking.

How Can We Navigate Conflict?

When we find ourselves in conflict with the needs or goals of others, there are different styles for how to navigate them. In the past decades, social and organizational psychologists have converged predominantly on the Dual Concern Model (Pruitt & Rubin, 1986). It states that when we find ourselves in conflict, two aspects determine how we approach it intuitively: our ability to assert our own needs and our ability to empathize with the needs of the other(s). Based on these two dimensions, five styles emerge:

- We can **avoid** the conflict by withdrawing from it. This can be done actively, by changing the subject or by physically moving away. But avoidance can also be done passively by not talking about it, by trying to remain neutral, or by avoiding certain people, relationships, or "hot" topics;
- We can **yield** by giving in to the other for the sake of harmony. This is usually driven by a fear of conflict and how hurtful it can be. But yielding can also take the shape of understating how conflict affects you, by smoothing it over or by maintaining (an often fake) sense of calm;
- We can **force** our needs onto the other(s) by taking an aggressive stance with the aim to win. This can take the shape of putting pressure on others, issuing threats and ultimatums, insulting them, or even using physical violence;
- We can use **problem-solving** or **integration** to seek ways to resolve a conflict in a way that meets the needs of both parties. This takes the shape of actively confronting the conflict together and openly talking about it. By objectively evaluating different viewpoints and experiences, we often find entirely new and creative solutions;
- Finally, we can **compromise** by giving everyone involved part of what they want, but not enough to make them truly happy with the outcomes. This style risks being a lazy form of the integrative style;

Which style is the best one?

Research has shown that Integration is the most effective way to navigate conflict in the majority of situations (for an overview, see Friedman et. al. 2000). Because this style takes the needs of all parties into account, it has the highest chance of resulting in gains for everyone. But more importantly, this style builds both the skills, trust, and an environment where further conflict can be navigated more effectively. Research shows that groups and individuals using this style experience less stressful conflict afterward. Contrary, the other styles tend to result in degradation of trust, safety, and an environment where future conflict is amplified.

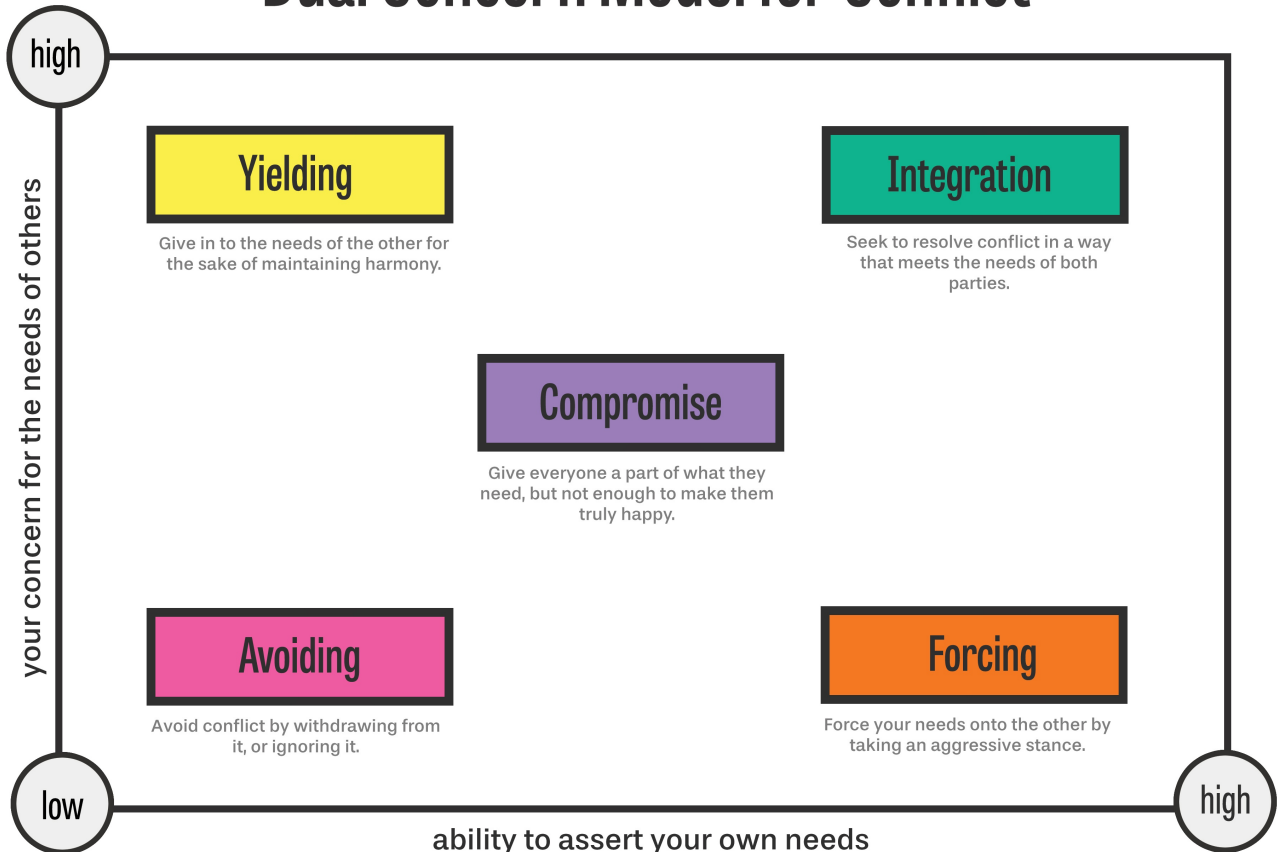
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- Friedman, R. A., Tidd, S. T., Currell, S. C. & Tsai, J. C. (2000). What goes around comes around: the impact of personal conflict style on work conflict and stress. The International Journal of Conflict Management, Vol 11., no. 1, pp. 32–55;



Dual Concern Model for Conflict



Attribution: Pruitt, D. G. & Rubin, J. (1986). Social Conflict: Escalation, Stalemate, and Settlement. Random House: New York;





Step 4: Invite Participants To Share Thoughts And Ideas With Impromptu Networking

Now that the group has a basic understanding of five styles of responding to conflict, you use the Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) to quickly let everyone share their ideas and thoughts.

Invitation

"Which of the five styles do you recognize the most in how you typically respond to conflict?"

Steps

1. **5 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what comes to mind.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the most interesting patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)





Step 5: Act Out The Different Styles Of Responding To Conflict With "Improv Prototyping"



By now, the group has a good understanding of the "Dual Concern Model For Conflict" and the different styles of how to respond to conflict. They've also shared personal ideas and thoughts on the styles they recognize. This is an ideal moment to try something completely different. You can talk about conflict for ages, experiencing it (in a fun way) makes it way more valuable. This is where the Liberating Structure [Improv Prototyping](#) comes into play.

The purpose of Improv Prototyping is to re-enact a challenging scenario faced by a group or an individual and work together to devise different behavioral strategies and interventions by acting it out. The twist that this structure brings is that the person who introduced the scenario becomes the 'director', while the others become the 'actors'. This allows the director to playfully experiment with strategies, behaviors, and interventions.

The emphasis here obviously lies on improvising; trying new things together and discovering and learning from what unfolds. Improv Prototyping actively engages groups to learn in other, less brainy ways. It invites people to learn by observing and by trying different behaviors in an improvised scenario. And it's a whole lot of fun.

Invitation

"Playfully replay a conflict that you faced and that could've benefitted from a different conflict style from you. Together with the actors, try out different styles and see what happens."

Steps

You can facilitate Liberating Structures in an infinite number of ways. Below are the steps we like to use, and that work for us. But certainly experiment with other steps to achieve the same goal. We've only used Improv Prototyping with in-person workshops. It's possible to use it virtually as well but might require creativity from the participants to make work.

1. **2 min** Form groups of six to eight people. Go for smaller groups if you facilitate it virtually.
2. **2 min** Invite people to individually think of a conflict they faced and could have benefitted from a different approach. If you sense substantial safety in this team, you can suggest people pick a conflict that they faced in this team. Otherwise, let people pick a conflict that didn't involve others in the room.
3. **5 min** Have people share the scenarios in their groups and pick the one that they feel is most suited for acting out in a short play;
4. **10 min** Explain that the person who introduced the scenario becomes the Creative Director of the play. The others become Actors. Working together, they will enact the scenario of the Creative Director and explore different ways in which the story can unfold based on different decisions and different behaviors. Working with the Actors, the Creative Director creates a rough script for a short play by deciding on roles, gathering props, offering lines, and devising a rough timeline;
5. **20 min** Invite the Actors of the groups to start enacting the play. The Creative Director offers feedback, makes suggestions, and offers (additional) lines as the actors progress through the scene. The Creative Director can start and stop the play as needed, or rewind and retry parts of the play. Encourage the groups to work together to try to come up with variations of behaviors, timelines, and dialogue to see what happens unfolds as the play unfolds. Expect a lot of laughter as teams playfully experiment with behavior;
6. **5 min** Invite groups to reflect on what they learned from the play, first individually then in their groups. What did they notice? What surprised them?

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website



- Blog post: [Playful learning with Improv Prototyping](#)



Step 6: Personal Next Steps

With Improv Prototyping, the group enacted the different styles of responding to conflict. In a playful way, everyone probably experienced how each style of conflict works out in a good or bad way. In the closing step of this workshop, everyone is asked to individually identify their personal next steps.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to address conflict more effectively? What is something, or a next step, you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"



Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?".

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)



Step 7: Closing

With this workshop, you helped the team to playfully explore five styles of responding to conflict, address the one's team members recognize, and make improvements accordingly.

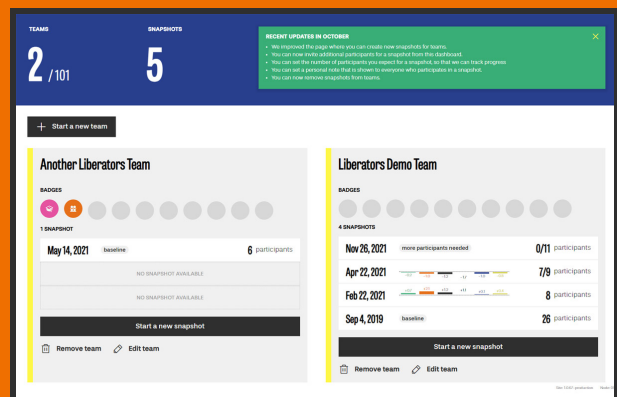
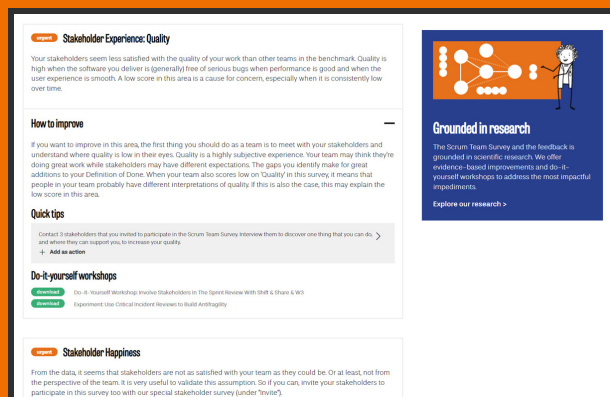
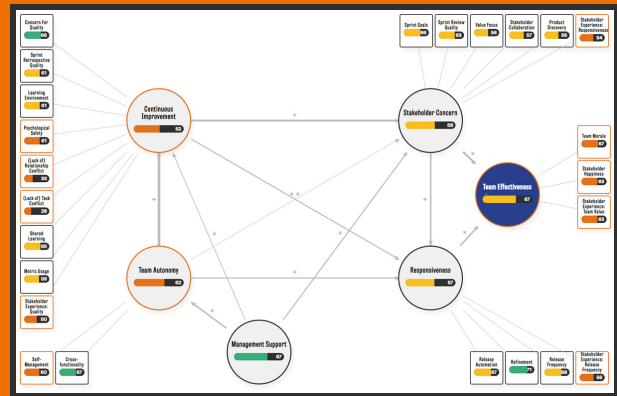
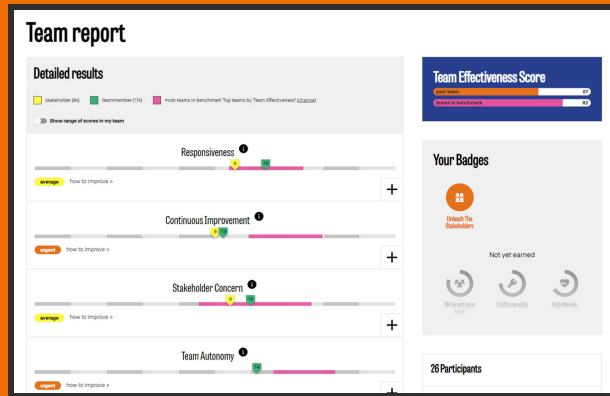
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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